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State could be first to reverse on pot

Question to repeal legalization likely to be on ballot; both sides brace for fight

By Bryan Hecht
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

A ballot fight to undo marijuana legalization in Massachusetts is heating up.

Anti-pot advocates said this week they've submitted enough final signatures to put a measure on the November ballot that would overturn state laws legalizing recreational cannabis.

At the same time, cannabis in-

dustry leaders on Thursday launched their opposition campaign, and said they're urging businesses to take the initiative seriously as well, after many had previously dismissed the proposal as unlikely to pass.

"I hope everybody understands how real of a threat it is," said Ryan Dominguez, chair of Stop the Repeal, an industry-backed movement.

The pot question will ask voters whether to repeal state laws legalizing, regulating, and taxing recreational cannabis sales, which were also passed by voter referendum in 2016. The sales generate hundreds of millions in annual tax revenue from dispensaries that have sprouted across the state. If successful, the initiative would mark the first time any state has reversed marijuana legalization.

The anti-pot proposal would join a field of other likely election questions ranging from repealing a 2024 firearms law to ending party prima-

ries. The state will officially certify the ballot questions in July.

"I'm cautiously optimistic and I look forward to voters getting the chance to [debate this]," said Wendy Wakeman, spokesperson for Coalition for a Healthy Massachusetts, the group backing the question, and a Massachusetts Republican Party strategist.

Industry groups attempted to block the question from ever coming to the ballot through a variety of legal challenges but were shot down.

Both sides now say they're gear-

MARIJUANA, Page A7

Very poor face new hurdle for MassHealth

Advocates, officials fear many will lose coverage

By Marin Wolf
GLOBE STAFF

MassHealth officials knew some 300,000 residents could lose coverage under tough new Trump administration requirements. But it's worse than they initially thought.

Program officials recently learned that up to another 110,000 people — parents, children, elderly adults, and people with disabilities — will have to take extra steps to continue their health insurance.

People on two federal safety-net programs aimed at extremely poor families with kids, the disabled, and the elderly have long automatically been enrolled in MassHealth, but that will end starting this fall. Over the next year, these MassHealth members will have to fill out additional paperwork to prove they are eligible for the state's low-income health insurance. Legal experts worry that this particularly vulnerable group may not know about or be able to navigate the new requirements in time to maintain their coverage.

"No one anticipated that [the Centers for Medicare & Medicaid Services] would look at low-income families with children and elderly and disabled people in cash-assistance programs and say, 'Oh yeah, there might be a few [who could work] in there, so the whole group now has to'" comply with the work requirement process, said Victoria Pulos, senior health attorney at the Massachusetts Law Reform Institute, an advocacy group.

MASSHEALTH, Page A6

Mental health questions swirl following son's fatal attack

By Lea Skene and John R. Ellement
GLOBE STAFF

WELLESLEY — It started with a father and his adult son casually kicking around a soccer ball.

They discussed the World Cup and plans to get dinner. The totally ordinary scene unfolded Thursday evening in a neighborhood park, a witness later told police.

Suddenly, the father was screaming and begging for help: "He's stabbing me, he's killing me," the older man said, according to prosecutors.

James F. Bennett III, 24, pleaded not guilty Friday morning to murdering his father, James F. Bennett Jr., 58.

The younger Bennett has a history of mental health issues, according to his attorney. He ultimately turned himself in to police after the deadly attack. He didn't realize his father had died, prosecutors said.

The stabbing unnerved local residents, leaving them with a sadly familiar sense of collective grief. In April, a Wellesley mother allegedly killed her two young children before attempting suicide, another horrific case that raised similar questions about mental illness and violence prevention.

WELLESLEY, Page A7



CHRISTIAN KANTOSKY FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

People danced to live music at Howl at the Moon in Boston last weekend. Last call there was extended to 3 a.m.

With extended bar hours, city gives the late-night life a whirl

Some say 3 a.m. should be new normal; others have reservations

By Yogev Toby
GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

It was just after 2 a.m. and dozens of dancing feet rattled the hardwood floor to the bumping rock music. Purple and red hues blanketed the sweating crowd as beer pints and mixed drinks slid across the counter.

This was way past normal last call in Boston, veering dangerously close to bedtime. But the Puritans had handed the revelers a special permission slip to keep the party going: the World Cup.

"I wish it could last," said Miguel Alvarez as he strode into another bar around the corner from the dancing crowds at 4th Wall on

Tremont Street. "The vibes have just been amazing."

During the World Cup, Massachusetts approved extending last call for alcohol sales to as late as 3 a.m., through the end of July. And Boston and Cambridge recently opened designated areas for public drinking with open containers as part of the World Cup and upcoming America 250 and Sail Boston celebrations.

Now, city officials, business owners, bartenders, and night owls are wondering whether this social experiment will finally answer whether Boston is capable of having a thriving nightlife scene.

Perhaps no one is more eager to find out

than Boston's so-called nightlife czar, Corean Reynolds, whom Mayor Michelle Wu appointed in 2023. She was tasked with cutting through a system mired in red tape, myriad regulations on alcohol, a ban on happy hour, and a lean MBTA schedule to improve Boston's dull nightlife.

She created grant programs, a nightlife committee, and a late-night food truck program. But Boston didn't seem to be shaking its reputation as the city that always sleeps.

Then came the Scots.

For about two weeks, kilted throngs of fans from Scotland's Tartan Army brought the party wherever they were, drank Boston

LATE NIGHTS, Page A5

French fans: calm and confident

Backers of Les Bleus bring a certain je ne sais quoi

By Chris Serres
GLOBE STAFF

They came for the escargot, slow-cooked in garlic and parsley butter, and the bourbon splashed with lemon juice.

They arrived in crisp polo shirts, with designer bags and puppies lounging in bassinets.

Over sips of strawberry spritzers, they talked of past and future trips to the Louvre and the Côte d'Azur.

As for the World Cup match flickering on the large screen perched above the sidewalk tables of the Petit Robert Bistro? That was a mere afterthought to their main event: the haute cuisine and the artful re-creation of a Parisian evening in Boston's South End.

French fans exuded a discreet confidence as they poured into Boston this week ahead of the team's final group match with Norway in Foxborough. On Friday, France forward Ousmane Dembele scored a sensational first-half hat-trick as Les Bleus beat Norway 4-1 to secure a top spot in Group I at the tournament.

FRENCH, Page A5



CRAIG F. WALKER/GLOBE STAFF

French soccer fans at Fan Fest in City Hall Plaza watched the match against Norway, which France won, 4-1.



Mower the merrier

Saturday: Clouds and sun.
High: 73-78. Low: 61-66.

Sunday: Partly sunny.
High: 70-75. Low: 63-68.

Sunrise: 5:09 Sunset: 8:25
Comics and Weather, **D4-5**.
Obituaries, **C10**.

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John Bolton, a former top adviser to President Trump who became an outspoken critic, pleaded guilty to mishandling classified information in a case that could send him to prison for up to five years. **A2.**

Two Republican candidates for Massachusetts statewide office won't appear on the September primary ballot after the commission that oversees ballots took issue with hundreds of nomination signatures they submitted. **B1.**

The Bruins traded their first-round pick and a conditional 2028 first-rounder to Utah for winger JJ Peterka. **C1.**

Boston Dynamics is planning to build a \$100 million manufacturing facility in Waltham that could employ up to 1,250 by 2033. **D1.**